

Reading Skills

Reading is a complex "cognitive process" of decoding symbols in order to construct or derive meaning (reading comprehension). When we read, we use our eyes to receive written symbols (letters, punctuation marks and spaces) and we use our brain to convert them into words, sentences and paragraphs that communicate something to us.

Reading is a means of language acquisition, communication, and of sharing information and ideas. Like all languages, it is a complex interaction between the text and the reader which is shaped by the reader's prior knowledge, experiences, attitude, and language community which is culturally and socially situated. The reading process requires continuous practice, development, and refinement. In addition, reading requires creativity and critical analysis. Reading can be silent (in our head) or aloud (so that other people can hear). Reading is a receptive skill - through it we receive information. But the complex process of reading also requires the skill of speaking, so that we can pronounce the words that we read. In this sense, reading is also a productive skill in that we are both receiving information and transmitting it.

The two most important sub skills of reading are:

1. **Skimming:** 'Skimming' a text means going through it quickly to get an overall idea of the content. We are not interested in details or any specific information while skimming.
2. **Scanning:** 'Scanning' on the other hand, involves searching the text for specific piece of information in which the reader is interested. For example finding a particular name or date given in the passage.

How to Read Effectively

1. Remain calm and cool while reading and read the text silently and very carefully.
2. Move from skimming to scanning. Go from the 'whole' to the 'parts', and not vice versa.
3. Don't pick up information from the text in small bits and pieces, try to read complete clauses or sentences in one go to understand the text well.
4. Don't get scared if you don't know the meaning of a particular word. Try to guess the meaning of the word in the context in which it is used.
5. Keep noting or underlining important points, ideas, names, definitions, days or dates in the passage.
6. Pay special attention to cohesive devices or discourse markers because these are 'signposts' provided by the writer. These are used in a text to indicate sequence of ideas and signal the writer's point of view. Understanding the writer's use of discourse markers is an important sub-skill of reading. These signposts are helpful because they indicate to the reader the relationship between two parts of the text. They also indicate the writer's opinions, mood or arguments.
7. Don't skip words or lines while reading as you may miss some important ideas.

8. The reading comprehension questions are generally asked in the sequence in which the text is arranged. However, be careful while you answer the questions.
9. The questions may be based on facts, information, overall understanding, reasons, causes, effects, merits, demerits, types, definitions, functions, purpose or inference. Read the question very carefully and understand it before looking for the answer.
10. Try to answer the questions in indirect speech making required changes in pronouns, verbs and tenses using correct connectors.
11. Answer all the questions based on the reading passage given to you. Don't add your own information or opinion until you are asked to do so.

Types of questions based on reading comprehension

(i) Multiple Choice Questions: In this category the students will be provided options to choose their answer from.

(ii) Blanks: In this category the students will be required to fill in the blanks by collecting information from the passage.

(iii) True/False: In this category the students will be required to write 'true' or 'false' in front of the given sentences based on their understanding of the given text.

(iv) Matching: In this category the students will be required to match the words/phrases given in the columns according to a particular criterion.

(v) Very Short Answers: In this category the students will be required to answer the questions in one word or a few words.

(vi) Short Answers: In this category the students will be required to answer the questions in one or two sentences.

(vii) Arranging the sentences: In this category the students may be required to arrange the given sentences in the sequence in which they appear in the text.

(viii) Mind Maps or Flow Charts: In this category the students may be required to complete the mind maps or flow charts by writing the required information.

Date Name Class & Section Roll No.

Unseen Passages for Reading Comprehension Prose

1. Read the passage given below carefully and answer the questions that follow.

Lincoln's Letter to His Son's Teacher

1. Abraham Lincoln was the sixteenth President of the United States, who served from March 1861 until his assassination in April 1865. He was a dynamic leader, a man of integrity who fought against slavery. He was very fond of his children and as a concerned father wrote the following letter to his son's Headmaster.
2. He will have to learn, I know, that all men are not just, that all men are not true, but teach him also that for every scoundrel there is a hero; that for every selfish politician, there is a dedicated leader.....Teach him for every enemy there is a friend. It will take time, I know, but teach him, if you can, that a dollar earned is of far more value than five found.....Teach him to learn to lose.....and also to enjoy winning. Steer him away from envy, if you can. Teach him the secret of quiet laughter. Let him learn early that the bullies are the easiest to lick.....Teach him, if you can, the wonder of books.....But also give him quiet time to ponder the eternal mystery of birds in the sky, bees in the sun and the flowers on a green hillside.
3. In the school, teach him that it is far honourable to fail than to cheat.....Teach him to have faith in his own ideas, even if everyone tells him they are wrong.....Teach him to be gentle with the gentle and tough with the tough. Try to give my son the strength not to follow the crowd when everyone is getting on the bandwagon.....Teach him to listen to all men.....but teach him also to filter all he hears on a screen of truth and take only the good that comes through.
4. Teach him, if you can, how to laugh when he is sad.....Teach him there is no shame in tears, teach him to scoff at cynics and to beware of too much sweetness.....Teach him to sell his brawn and brain to the highest bidders but never to put a price-tag on his heart and soul. Teach him to close his ears to a howling mob and to stand and fight if he thinks he is right. Treat him gently, but do not cuddle him because only the test of fire makes fine steel. Let him have the courage to be impatient.....Let him have the patience to be brave. Teach him always to have sublime faith in himself because then he will have sublime faith in mankind. This is a big order, but see what you can do because he is such a little fellow, my son.

(i) Answer the following questions briefly.

(a) “He will have to learn, I know, that all men are not just”. Who is ‘he’ in this sentence?

.....

.....

.....

(b) Why does Lincoln not want his son to be cuddled?

.....

.....

.....

(c) What should Lincoln’s son do after listening to all men?

.....

.....

.....

(ii) Lincoln’s letter is full of opposite words or contrary terms. Write the contrary terms used by Lincoln for each of the following words:

(a) scoundrel.....

(b) dedicated leader.....

(c) enemy.....

(d) gentle.....

(e) lose.....

(iii) Complete the sentences by taking information from the passage.

(a) A dollar is of far value than

(b) Apart from reading books one should.....

.....

(c) One should never sell one’s.....

(d) Lincoln’s son can have sublime faith in mankind only when

.....

.....

Date Name Class & Section Roll No.

2. Read the passage given below carefully and answer the questions that follow.

'Freeegans' Find Treasure in Trash

1. The Times of India: A new movement in Singapore that seeks to reduce the amount of consumer waste in the affluent city-state is scavenging for unwanted goods, some in near-mint condition, that migrant workers can send home for the holidays. “Freeegans”, broadly defined as people committed to cutting wasteful production and consumption, have connected with thousands of foreign labourers from lower-income countries, many of whom cannot afford the products sold in the city’s shiny shopping malls.
2. In Singapore, the luxurious backdrop for the movie “Crazy Rich Asians”, what passes as trash for one household, ends up in a shipping container on its way to the home country of a migrant worker. “We should give whatever we have in excess to the poor instead of throwing it away, said Colin Lau, a member of the “Freegan in Singapore” Facebook group whose 6500 members includes Singaporeans and foreigners.
3. Some members like Lau, search dumpsters and rubbish bins retrieving discarded items and re-using them or sharing with others in an effort to save money and the environment. The freeegans often post photos of their discoveries, including barely-worn clothing, jewellery, electronics and luxury goods such as handbags. They also share items with migrant workers at weekly giveaways. At one such gathering before the year-end holidays, freeegans held a lucky draw for discarded items and electronics.
4. Virginia Andrade, 52, said this year she was able to send home two television sets, a laptop for her son, and two wheelchairs for her mother and sisters who are unable to walk after suffering strokes. “Since I have started sending things back we don’t have to buy clothes anymore and we use money for food and school fee instead,” Andrade said. “I’ve told my family that the items they receive are donated and some are from the dumpsters. “They are so thankful to Colin and his friends”, she added.

(i) Answer the following questions briefly.

(a) Who are “Freegans”?

.....

.....

.....

(b) The two purposes of the “Freegan” movement are:

.....

.....

.....

(c) What happens to trash in Singapore?

.....

.....

.....

(d) What did Virginia's family receive from her?

.....

.....

.....

(e) What does Virginia do with the saved money?

.....

.....

.....

(ii) Write true or false against each of the following sentences.

(a) Singapore was the setting of the movie, “Crazy Rich Asians”

(b) We should throw away what we have in excess.

(c) Freegans buy the items and send them to low income countries.

(d) The facebook group of freegans has more than 6000 members.

(iii) Find a word in the passage, which means the same as ‘searching through waste for the things that can be used or eaten’. (Paragraph 1)

Date Name Class & Section Roll No.

3. Read the passage given below carefully and answer the questions that follow.

Dipa Karmakar: The Small Wonder *A Book Review*

1. The Tribune: Ever since Dipa Karmakar won the bronze medal in the vault event of the women's artistic gymnastics at the 2014 Glasgow Commonwealth Games, she became a trailblazer for a sport which had no presence in India. It has been close to two years now that she has resurrected the sport in the country, capturing the nation's imagination with a fourth-place finish at the Rio Olympics. A book on her was a long time coming.
2. Authors Digvijay Singh Deo and Vimal Mohan begin by recounting the events leading up to the day in August 2016 when Dipa Karmakar became the first Indian gymnast to finish fourth at the Rio Olympics. The narrative then moves on to Agartala, Tripura, describing it as gymnastics capital from the 1960s to the 1980s. Dipa recalls the contribution of late Dalip Singh, an NIS-qualified coach whom she anoints as the godfather of the sport in Tripura. Dalip who hailed from a farmers' family in Mahendragarh, Haryana, is credited with raising the first crop of national level gymnasts from the region. Bishweshwar Nandi, Dipa's coach was one of his disciples.
3. The book traces the journey of a five-year-old from a local club in Agartala to a 23-year-old, who became the first Indian gymnast to reach an Olympics final. From her formative years to initial failures in sub-junior nationals and consequent feats in the Nationals, the book captures all details of her life and not just in gymnastics. The 25-year-old comes across as a bubbly, small-town girl who leads a simple, cheerful life. An entire chapter has been devoted to the Produnova, Dipa's signature move on the vault and now famous as the Death Vault, which made the four-foot something a celebrity in the gymnastics world. The book also pays tribute to pioneers of the sport in the country-Bharat Kishore, Deb Burman, Mantu Debnath, whom Dipa had idolised since childhood. The authors have been able to capture her true persona: the sincerity and the honesty of a small-town girl who had lofty aspirations and nerves of steel.
4. Written in first person account and an easy language, the book makes for a racy read. There is, however, an occasional botch-up in numbers, year of occurrence of an event and some typographical errors. The authors' notes and acknowledgements though repetitive, make for an interesting read. In their individual acknowledgements, the trio has thanked profusely close to 100 persons if not more, all duly named, including kids in their extended families, bankers, IPS officers, revenue officials, public relations executives, and not-to-miss, office bosses, without whom the book would not have seen the light of day. Still, there are many whom they have not been able to name but have not missed an opportunity to express their gratefulness to them as well.

(i) Answer the following questions briefly.

(a) What is the name of the book written on Dipa Karmakar?

.....

.....

.....

(b) Where did Dalip belong to?

.....

.....

.....

(c) What is the height of Dipa Karmakar?

.....

.....

.....

(d) How does the easy language of the book help the reader?

.....

.....

.....

(ii) Find words from the passage which mean the same as the following:

(a) a person who is the first to do something (Paragraph 1).....

(b) to bring back to use something that has been stopped or forgotten(Paragraph 1).....

(c) a mistake or blunder(Paragraph 4).....

(iii) State whether the following sentences are true or false.

(a) Dipa Karmakar never failed in any event.

(b) Agartala has always been gymnastics capital of India

(c) Produnova throws light on Dipa's childhood.

(iv) Find a word in the passage, which is an antonym of 'final'. (Paragraph 3)

.....

Date Name Class & Section Roll No.

4. Read the passage given below carefully and answer the questions that follow.

At Home Abroad
By: APJ Abdul Kalam Azad

1. I think it was in 2006 that the President of the European Parliament, Joseph Borrel Fontelles called on me at Rashtrapati Bhawan. During our discussions, he talked to me at length about a topic that is close to my heart, the Evolution of Enlightened Citizens, which he had read on my website. He asked me numerous questions on the subject. The questions were thoughtful, deep and purposeful. After our discussion, he invited me to address the European Parliament, which had 785 members representing twenty-seven member states of the European Union. The parliament is the only directly elected body of the European Union. He also requested that I address the parliament before his term as president ended in December 2006. However, because of my various commitments during 2006, I was unable to give the address till 25 April 2007. By that time Hans-Gert Pottering had taken over as president from Fontelles.
2. As the address was an important one, I started preparing well before the commencement of my tour. I had several brainstorming sessions with friends, intellectuals, political leaders, scientists and the youth. I also composed a poem, 'Message from Mother Earth' especially for the occasion. The poem is a reflection on how the European Nations, which went through various brutal wars as they fought one another, successfully converged to form the European Union with a focus on the economic development, prosperity, peace and happiness of all the member nations. It is indeed a pioneering initiative in regional cooperation.
3. When I reached the European Parliament on the morning of 25 April, I was welcomed by the President and his colleagues. It made for an impressive sight to see the 785 representatives of the European Union, and the overflowing visitor's gallery.
4. My address on the occasion, titled 'Dynamics of Unity of Nations', emphasized the need for a confluence of civilizations, based on India's historical experience, instead of a conflict of civilizations. My speech highlighted the evolution of enlightened citizenship, which has three components: education with a value system; religion transforming into spirituality; and societal transformation through national development. I also spoke on the necessity of achieving energy independence in India and Europe and outlined a mechanism for its realization. My lecture was cheered periodically. At the end of my address, I recited the poem that I had composed specifically for the occasion, with the permission of all the members.
5. As I completed reading my poem, I was touched by the moving and spontaneous response from every member of the parliament. The standing ovation I received was indeed a tribute to our nation. In response, I conveyed the greetings of the one billion people of India to the citizens of the European Union Countries. During his concluding remarks after my address, President Pottering said, I quote, 'Mr President Abdul Kalam, in the name of European Parliament, I want to thank you for this most important and inspiring speech. This was one of the extraordinary speeches we have ever heard from a statesman, scientist and a poet. This is unique. All the best to this great nation India, all the best to our cooperation between the great nation India and the European Union, all the best Mr. President'
6. After my address, many members wanted to discuss specific aspects of the speech with me. The general observation was that India is a great nation and is rich in human values.

(i) Answer the following questions briefly.

(a) When was Joseph's tenure about to end?

.....

.....

.....

(b) What is the purpose of European Union?

.....

.....

.....

(c) How did Kalam prepare for his speech?

.....

.....

.....

.....

(d) What are the components of evolution of enlightened citizenship?

.....

.....

.....

(d) What was the response of the representatives of the European Union after hearing the poem?

.....

.....

.....

(e) What did the members observe about India?

.....

.....

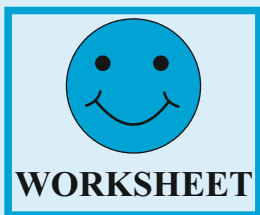
.....

(f) Find a word in the passage, which means the same as 'violent and cruel'. (Paragraph 2)

.....

(g) Find a word in the passage, which is an antonym of 'diverge'. (Paragraph 2)

.....

Date Name Class & Section Roll No. **5. Read the passage given below carefully and answer the questions that follow.***Literary Terms or Figures of Speech*

Literary terms describe the various techniques that writers use to create a particular emotional effect on the readers' mind. It is use of literary terms that gives a special meaning to a piece of text be it prose or poetry. It beautifies the language and adds to its charm. Here are some common literary terms.

1. A **simile** is a figure of speech that directly compares two things. Although similes and metaphors are similar, similes explicitly use connecting words such as *like*, *as*, *so*, *than*, or various verbs such as *resemble*. Example: "O My Love's like a red, red rose." "A Red, Red Rose," by Robert Burns.
2. A **metaphor** is a figure of speech that refers to something as being the same as another thing for rhetorical effect. It may provide clarity or identify hidden similarities between two ideas. Whereas a simile compares two items, a metaphor directly equates them, and does not use "like" or "as" as does a simile. Example:
"All the world's a stage,
And all the men and women merely players;
They have their exits and their entrances[...]"
—William Shakespeare, *As You Like It*
3. **Alliteration** is the repetition of initial sounds in neighbouring words. Example: "She sells sea shells on the sea shore." The other two figures of speech related to repetition of sounds are consonance and assonance. consonance is the repetition of a consonant sound at any position in two or more words whereas assonance is the repetition of a vowel sound in two or more words.
4. **Refrain** is a line or group of lines that repeats at regular intervals, in different stanzas. It not only gives a rhythmic effect to the poem but also emphasises the central idea of the poem.
5. **Personification** is a figure of speech where human qualities are given to animals, objects or ideas. Example: The leaves were dancing in the rain.
6. **Onomatopoeia** is a word that phonetically imitates, resembles or suggests the source of the sound that it describes. Onomatopoeia (as an uncountable noun) refers to the property of such words. Common occurrences of onomatopoeias include animal noises such as, "miaow", "roar" or "chirp". Examples: tinkling bells or rustling of silk etc.
7. **Irony**, in its broadest sense, is a rhetorical device, literary technique, or event in which what appears, on the surface, to be the case, differs radically from what is actually the case. Irony may be divided into categories such as verbal, dramatic, and situational. In *City Lights* the audience knows that Charlie Chaplin's character is not a millionaire, but the blind flower girl (Virginia Cherrill) believes him to be rich.
8. A **transferred epithet** is a figure of speech in which an epithet (or adjective) grammatically qualifies a noun other than the person or thing it is actually describing. A transferred epithet often involves shifting a modifier from the animate to the inanimate, as in the phrases "cheerful money," "sleepless night," and "suicidal sky."
9. **Pun**, also called paronomasia, is a form of word play that suggests two or more meanings, by exploiting multiple meanings of words, or of similar-sounding words, for an intend. Examples: (i) A bicycle can't stand on its own because it is two-tired. (ii) No matter how much you push the envelope, it will still be stationery.
10. **Oxymoron** is a figure of speech in which two opposite ideas are joined to create an effect. The common oxymoron phrase is a combination of an adjective proceeded by a noun with contrasting meanings. Examples: "cruel kindness" or "living death" "Tragic comedy" etc.
11. A **Paradox** is a self contradictory statement that contains two opposite facts. Example: Success is precious for the people who never succeed.

12. Allusion is an indirect reference to a person, event, or thing in history or literature.

13. Hyperbole is a figure of speech in which the writer exaggerates and makes something sound bigger or more impressive than it really is. Example: Her eyes were deeper than the ocean.

14. Imagery: When a writer uses words to create a picture in your mind, it is called imagery. There are various types of imagery. Many of them are related to our five senses which help us create the mental image of the thing we are reading about. Visual Imagery creates sight experience; olfactory imagery, smell; auditory imagery, sound; gustatory imagery, taste; and kinaesthetic imagery, touch.

(i) Fill in the blanks with correct words based on your understanding of the literary terms.

(a) The figure of speech used in the sentence, “He had held his head in his hands”

is.....

(b) The repetition of the line, “For men may come and men may go, but I go on forever” in the poem, ‘The

Brook’ is an example of.....

(c) As black as coal is an example of.....

(d) “His spear was bigger than the diameter of the earth” is an example of.....

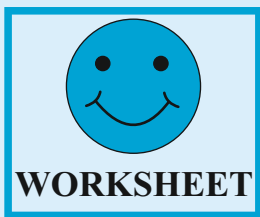
(e) John Keats’ poem ‘Ode to Autumn’ presents a pen picture of the season autumn presenting visual images, sounds and ripeness of the season. This is an example of.....

(f) “Death lays his icy hands on both the king and the pauper”. In this sentence Death is treated as a living thing. This is an example of.....

(g) The phrase, “Foolish wisdom” is an example of.....

(h) The sentence, “Reading while sunbathing makes you well red” uses the figure of speech.....

.....on the words, ‘read’ and ‘red’.



Date

Name

Class & Section

Roll No.

Unseen Passages for Reading Comprehension

Poetry

6. Read the poem given below carefully and answer the questions that follow.

Scaffolding

*Masons, when they start upon a building,
Are careful to test out the scaffolding;
Make sure that planks won't slip at busy points,
Secure all ladders, tighten bolted joints.
And yet all this comes down when the job's done
Showing off walls of sure and solid stone.
So, if, my dear, there sometimes seem to be
Old bridges breaking between you and me
Never fear. We may let the scaffolds fall
Confident that we have built our wall.*

-Seamus Heaney

(i) Read the following questions and answer the questions briefly:

(a) What do masons test when they build a wall?

.....

.....

(b) How is scaffolding tested?

.....

.....

(c) What happens to the scaffolding when the wall is built?

.....

.....

(c) What does the wall symbolize in the last line?

.....

.....

(iii) Find words from the poem which mean the same as the following:

(a) a temporary structure on the outside of a building

(b) a long narrow piece of board, used for making structure to walk on.....

Date Name Class & Section Roll No.

7. Read the poem given below carefully and answer the questions that follow.

Thomas Alva Edison

*Thomas Alva Edison,
A most unusual boy,
Never really bothered much
With any childish toy.*

*His teacher thought he couldn't learn
And sent him home from school,
But Tommy's mother knew for sure
He wasn't any fool.*

*He worked as newsboy on a train,
He learned to telegraph.
The way he concentrated
Made some people laugh.*

*Thomas Elva Edison
Had inventions by the score.
In his laboratory
He kept inventing more.*

*The photograph, electric light
(With fuses, sockets, too),
A super storage battery,
And movies, were a few.*

*If not for Mr. Edison
How dull our lives would be!
We might not have the radio,
The X-ray, or TV.*

-Vivan Gouled

(I) Read the questions given below and the options provided for each question carefully. On the basis of your reading of the poem, tick the option that you consider the most appropriate.

(A) Thomas Alva Edison was an unusual boy because-

(a) his teachers disliked him

(c) he played with toys

(b) other children disliked him

(d) he did not play with toys

(B) Edison did not invent-

- | | |
|-----------------------------|--------------|
| (a) electric light | © phonograph |
| (b) a super storage battery | (d) engine |

(C) A newsboy is a person who-

- | | |
|-------------------|-------------------------|
| (a) collects news | (c) publishes newspaper |
| (b) edits news | (d) sells newspapers |

(ii) Complete the sentences given below by supplying information from the poem:

- (a) Thomas Alva Edison never bothered.....
.....
- (b) Edison's teachers thought that
.....
- (c) Without Mr. Edison, we might not have
.....

(iii) What is the rhyme scheme of the poem?

.....

(iv) What was Edison's nickname?

.....

(v) Enlist a few things invented by Edison.

- a)
- b)
- c)
- d)

Date Name Class & Section Roll No.

8. Read the poem given below carefully and answer the questions that follow.

We Who Love Books

*Some books I'll never give away,
Though old and worn, their binding torn,
Upon my shelves they'll always stay,
Alive, still read, still fresh each dawn,
Their magic moments never gone.*

*Familiar friends, these timeless tales
Have been with me since I was ten,
And as I turn their pages once again
I feel and love their old refrain.*

*Great verse, great thoughts, still stand the test
Of time that's passing by so fast.....
These good companions never fail
To give me joy, to nourish me.
We who love books will always be
The lucky ones, our minds set free.*

Ruskin Bond

(i) Read the questions given below carefully and tick the correct option.

(A) The poem is about the poet and

- (a) old books on the shelves of the people who love books
- (b) old books on the shelves of the poet's house
- (c) difference between old and new books

(B) The poet wants to keep his books even though they are old and torn because

- (a) they give him joy and he loves them.
- (b) they are unlike his friends.
- (c) his other friends have failed him

(C) People who love books are lucky because books

- (a) teach them to love mankind
- (b) make time stand still for them
- (c) enable them to explore the world of poetry and ideas

(D) 'Stand the test of time' means to

- (a) survive in their original form
- (b) continue to be loved over the years
- (c) be with someone for several years

(E) 'I feel and love their old refrain' means that the poet

- (a) can hear the words from the old books
- (b) can write all the words he has learnt from the books
- (c) remembers the lines he has read repeatedly

(ii) Complete the following sentences.

(a) The people who love reading books will always be.....and
their.....

(b) The books the poet talks about have been with him.....
.....

(c) Although the books are old and worn, they will always
.....

(iii) Find words from the poem which mean the same as the following:

(a) stories that will always be loved.....

(b) lines that have been read over and over again.....

(iv) Name the poetic device used in the phrase 'familiar friends'.

.....

(v) Why do books never fail?

.....

.....

.....